

Apple PMPs

Falling like apples from trees

Apples PMPs are known the world over and need no formal introduction. We have with us the latest iterations of their four product lines; the iPod Shuffle, iPod Nano, iPod Classic, (called Classic 6G), and the iPod Touch 2G.

The iPod Touch 2G is noticeably slimmer than its predecessor and has a curved back; this contour adds sleekness but some may not like



the way it feels. Apple added a loudspeaker; a feature that was sorely needed. Volume buttons are also a much needed addition, although they feel tacky and seem cheaply built. Overall, we were disappointed with the look of the new device — it seems to lack the class that the original had, and the glaring black volume buttons are hard to use. The volume of the loudspeaker is woefully inadequate for even silent environments. The screen size and characteristics remain unchanged. The new Touch feels a little lighter also, and we found out that this might be due to Apple using a slightly smaller capacity battery. While some will praise the new slim shape and reduced

weight others will curse the reduced battery life — we noticed a reduction in playtime of a couple of hours.

On the application front, small applets like Stocks, Weather and Google Maps have been added, which were available as paid software downloads with version 2.0 of the Touch firmware. The new Touch is available in eight and 16 GB versions; there is no 32 GB version as of now.

The Touch interface remains its splendid self, as does its wonderful PMP abilities. Music quality remains the same, and we tested the Touch with our audiophile grade headphones and tube amp — wonderful! Video playback is the same as the previous Touch — superb — although we figure a bigger screen would really spice up video playback.

The iPod Classic has always been desired for its enormous storage. The new Classic drops in a 120 GB HDD in lieu of the 80 GB version on the earlier Classic. However, there's no replacement for the colossal 160 GB version; 200 GB anyone? The 2.5-inch display is largely unchanged and is sharp enough for movies. The Classic is available in two colours — silver and black. Build quality remains



the same and the new Classic retains its tank-like dimensions and in-hand feel. In terms of add-on features there isn't much more than the previous version. Sound quality is superb, although the Classic has very slightly rounded off highs — something which is revealed in the Touch. Note that most users won't even notice this, unless you use audiophile grade headphones like Sennheisers HD 650 or Grados RS-1 and a good headphone amplifier.

The new Nano is dubbed as the Nano *Chromatic*. This is because it's now available in many more colours including new ones like yellow, orange and violet in addition to the classic ones. The new Nano is more like the Nanos of old rather than the previous model which was nearly square and is being called the Nano *Widescreen* now. This



Nano is oblong; and the body is curved ditto the glass screen, which fits flush into this curve. By far this seems the funkiest change in terms of shape from amongst the new models. The Nano has got a 2-inch display that looks ultra crisp, and the inbuilt

accelerometer allows the screen to orient sideways. This also allows you to shake the Nano to skip a track; although this is nothing novel yet the inclusion of this feature is welcome. In terms of sound quality the Nano impresses; although it's a hairsbreadth behind the Classic and the Touch in terms of detailing at the top end of the sound spectrum.

The new Shuffle is downright cute. Available in five colours and a neat looking clasp that fastens anywhere



be it your belt, shorts or pocket. There's a bundled dock which allows connecting the Shuffle to your PC for syncing. The LED battery indicator has three status levels green, which means there's lots of juice, amber which means low battery and red which indicates the show is nearly over. The buttons on the Shuffle are top class in terms of build quality. Available in 1 GB and 2 GB versions the Shuffle is for those who want to take their groove with them anywhere. Sound quality is surprisingly good — those who think the Shuffle is any less for its diminutive size, think again. Although people looking to use the Shuffle will almost never need audiophile grade sound, you will not be disappointed as a casual user.

At Rs 13,000 the iPod Classic gives the word *Goliath* a whole new meaning. It's a great deal for someone looking to cart around a huge MP3 collection. If you do not need to lug around 50 odd GB of music you may want to look at the iPod Touch 2G. At Rs 12,800 it's got a large screen, unbeatable touch and finger swipe interface and lovely music playback. For the young and funky, or those looking to spend less, the new Nanos will excite. The eight GB version costs Rs 8,200. The 2 GB Shuffle costs Rs 3,200; this is about right for an entry level MP3 player. People may be tempted to look at cheap options that have screens, but the Shuffle will have better sound quality. Period.

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Microsoft Life Cam VX 5500

A webcam of many faces

The new Microsoft Life cam VX 5500 stands out with its intuitive design and beautiful looks that can compliment any notebook or desktop computer.

The VX 5500 has a VGA resolution of 640 x 480 that is good enough to take care of all the conferencing you plan to do. The overall video quality is good and you will not face any problem even in low light conditions. We would have loved to have manual focusing on this, but sadly there was none available — you will have to keep the camera at the right distance to keep it in focus. The VX 5500 sports a Uni-Directional microphone, so sounds are picked up from anywhere in the room — good or bad depending on the ambient noise. The microphone features

acoustic noise and echo cancellation.

The VX 5500 has a slim and flat folding stand that makes it easy to store and transport, and the same stand allows you to clip it on to your LCD monitor. Microsoft also adds a touch of color to this webcam with interchangeable faceplates. White blue and red face plates are bundled, but that's about it for choice — you can't buy more.

Installing the VX 5500 might be a slight hassle for people who don't have an active Internet connection, as its software installation utility will not install the VX 5500 until it downloads the latest software driver version for the webcam.

Designed for the latest



utility peripherals. However, remember that it doesn't have features like manual focusing and motion detection, which other manufacturers (Logitech and Creative) are incorporating in their webcams in the same price range.

Specifications

VGA Resolution CMOS sensor, Flat folding design, USB 2.0, Noise cancelling microphone

Contact: Microsoft Hardware
Phone: 9886328580
E-mail: geethakb@microsoft.com
Web site: www.microsoft.com/india/edd/
Price: Rs 4,522

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★
Performance	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

BenQ MP771

For Cramped-up Space

Projectors are finding their way into your living room as home entertainment systems. The latest innovation that is coming in projectors is short throw lenses and mind it the BenQ MP771 is a classic example of it. With its short throw lens this projector can project up to a 74-inch display from a distance of 1 meter.



Good thing for people who have really cramped up spaces in office or at home.

The BenQ MP 771 is compact, and uses a 280 watt Osram lamp, which company claims will last for almost 4000 hours under economy mode or 3000 hours under normal usage. You will need to change the lamp much before that of course, or suffer reduced brightness.

This projector has a native XGA resolution of 1024 x 768, but sup-

ports resolution from VGA (640 x 480) to SXGA (1280 x 1024). It features a 16.7 million color palette to give a richer color experience. We played a couple of movies and videos on it and it was able to reproduce superb colors with great contrast and sharpness. You can also tweak color saturation and hue according to your needs.

The projector has a small footprint. This projector has an impressive start up and shut down times; it took 1 minute to start the first time, and 32 seconds the next time. Shutting down is fast; just 29 seconds.

This projector comes with different video input ports like DVI, D-Sub, S-Video and Composite video, but at its price, were expecting it to have HDMI support too.

This projector scores with a great short throw lens and vibrant video reproduction, but lack of an HDMI port and a price tag of Rs 80,000 might make you want to look elsewhere.

Specifications

Native XGA resolution (1024 x 768), Resolution support of up to 1280 x 1024, Short throw lens, 2000 : 1 contrast ratio, 4:3 and 16:9 aspect ratio compatible

Contact: BenQ India
Phone: 011-43531700
E-mail: sales.enquiry@benq.com
Web site: www.benq.co.in
Price: Rs 80,548

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★
Performance	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★